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Why So Wary? (1953–1956)

We did not come to an agreement about anything. I don't mean to say we disagreed about everything. We didn't try to come to an agreement.

—John Foster Dulles, US secretary of state, on his meeting with Jawaharlal Nehru in May 1953[1]

It was obvious that we did not feel in the same way as the American Government about communism and the way to combat it … We felt that [the] American reaction to the communist countries was not only exaggerated and dangerous but actually was likely to produce the very opposite results than those aimed at, more especially in Asia.… American policy has led the United States to side with colonial and reactionary elements in Asia, and as a result of that, had almost presented to the communist countries an ideal opportunity to pose as liberating agencies. Mere force and threats of war might frighten people for a while, but would never succeed in convincing people.

—Jawaharlal Nehru, prime minister of India, to George Allen, April 24, 1954[2]

During his 1949 visit to the United States, Nehru had received an honorary doctorate from Columbia University. In 1953, the man who had handed him that degree, former university president and retired general Dwight D.